

Leptomeryx

Herds of tiny, deerlike mammals known as *Leptomeryx* fed in the forests and grasslands of North America for more than 13 million years. *Leptomeryx* was not much bigger than a hare and probably just as nimble, darting around on its tiny hooves in the undergrowth. This little plant-eater flourished in huge numbers and was probably an easy snack for predators of the time.

Leptomeryx

LEP-toe-MERRIX

- **When** 38–25 million years ago (Paleogene)
- **Fossil location** USA
- **Habitat** Grasslands
- **Length** 1 ft (0.3 m)
- **Diet** Mostly plants

Leptomeryx was a ruminant—a hoofed mammal that brings up food from its stomach to chew a second time. During the period in which it lived, the climate changed and grasslands replaced forest. Fossils show that the teeth of *Leptomeryx* became stronger at the same time—perhaps it was evolving to live on rougher foods such as grass, which contains tiny flecks of glass to protect itself from herbivores. *Leptomeryx* was built like a deer but had no antlers, although males had small tusks formed from their canine teeth.

